

Chapter 158-1

Gu Xingyue sat there in a daze for a long time.

She had thought that after experiencing so much, she should be able to remain calm and unfazed.

Yet after Liang Shi spoke those words with such certainty, her emotions still surged.

After a moment, Gu Xingyue finally said slowly: "Let me think about it."

She didn't give a definite answer.

Gu Xingyue lowered her head and took a sip of water, her hands resting on the warm cup. Her gaze passed through the clean floor-to-ceiling windows, watching the surging crowd outside.

Her eyes were hazy and vacant, making it impossible to tell what she was thinking.

After a long while, Gu Xingyue stood up. "I'll be going now."

Liang Shi stood up as well. "Okay."

When she reached the door, Gu Xingyue suddenly stopped and turned back a few steps, her voice very soft. "Could you let me see the test report?"

"I'll ask my friend." Liang Shi said. "To see if she can take a photo and send it to me."

"Okay." Gu Xingyue paused. "Send it to my WeChat when you get it."

Liang Shi was startled. She was just about to ask if she was still using that account when she saw Gu Xingyue open her phone, pull up a QR code, and push it in front of her.

Liang Shi immediately scanned it.

After Gu Xingyue left, Liang Shi drove around aimlessly for a while.

Driving without any destination.

In the end, she unknowingly drove to the entrance of their residential complex.

On the Yujiang Bridge, traffic still flowed like shuttles. The water in the Yujiang River flowed slowly beneath the thin layer of ice.

Nothing had changed.

When the car pulled over to the side of the road, she still found it hard to believe and smiled bitterly to herself.

Then she tilted her head up to look at the high-rise.

After a while, her neck started to ache, and only then did she lower her head.

Liang Shi curled her fingers and lightly tapped the steering wheel. The rhythmic tapping sound seemed to be giving herself courage. She didn't know how long this went on—it seemed like a very long time—before she finally grabbed her coat from the back seat, casually slipped it on, stretched out her long arm, and pushed open the car door.

The biting winter wind instantly penetrated her skin, pouring in through her collar, making her shiver from the cold.

It had only been a few days since she'd been back, yet she felt a sense of apprehension about returning home.¹

Liang Shi pulled her coat collar tight and walked quickly to the entrance of the apartment building.

The first floor had the usual mailbox area. She found their unit's compartment, entered the password, and opened it—it was completely empty inside.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't put the divorce agreement in the storage compartment downstairs, nor had she contacted her.

As if she hadn't seen her message at all.

But she had disappeared for so many days with her phone turned off—Xu Qingzhu couldn't possibly not have noticed.

So the most likely possibility was that she was avoiding it.

Liang Shi couldn't figure out what Xu Qingzhu was thinking.

She had thought she understood Xu Qingzhu very well.

But at a time like this, Xu Qingzhu's behavior once again exceeded her expectations.

Liang Shi had only guessed two possible outcomes: either she would call to question her, or she would sign the divorce agreement and leave it downstairs.

But it was neither.

Xu Qingzhu acted as if she didn't know about this matter, continuing to go to and from work normally, and hadn't contacted her again.

In the past, they had contacted each other very frequently, sending many messages almost every day.

Even when she was filming.

Except for those few days when Xu Qingzhu first started having nightmares, they sent slightly fewer messages, but still about twenty-something each day.

Just casual chatting or idle talk—they would send messages.

Not like now, where they had tacitly cut off contact.

Yet without mentioning the divorce matter again.

Liang Shi sat on the bench downstairs, and after much deliberation, she still sent Xu Qingzhu a message: 【I came to get the divorce agreement. You didn't put it in the cabinet downstairs. What's going on?】

Even looking at it through the screen, it was a very harsh-sounding message, appearing somewhat cold.

After just a moment, the note at the top of Xu Qingzhu's chat box changed to "The other party is typing."

Then Liang Shi watched as "Zhuzi" and "The other party is typing" kept alternating. After about ten minutes of this, Liang Shi finally received a reply.

Xu Qingzhu: 【I'm considering it.】

Liang Shi: ...

Xu Qingzhu sent another message: 【Don't you want to meet and talk about this?】

Liang Shi: ...

Although separated by a screen, Liang Shi could already picture Xu Qingzhu's cold eyes in her mind. She would look over coldly, and her already cool voice combined with her indifferent tone would probably make Liang Shi feel like she had gone back to when she first transmigrated and met her.

No, perhaps it would be even worse than that.

It was very clear: Xu Qingzhu was angry.

But Liang Shi had no choice.

She didn't want to discuss this topic with Xu Qingzhu face to face. If Xu Qingzhu got angry, she would feel terrified. If Xu Qingzhu cried, she might soften. But a decision had to be made—hesitating would only hurt people more deeply. It was better to cut through the mess quickly.

That was why Liang Shi had left alone that morning.

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1. The phrase "近乡情怯" (jìn xiāng qíng qiè) is a Chinese idiom meaning "the closer one gets to home, the more anxious one becomes." It describes the mixed feelings of nervousness, apprehension, and emotional turmoil one experiences when returning home after a long absence, often due to uncertainty about what changes may have occurred or how one will be received. ⇐

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After thinking it over, Liang Shi replied: 【Let's not. There's nothing to say.】

She had watched countless breakup scenes, acted in countless breakup scenes, but when it actually came to her own turn, every single word felt impossible to say.

Every character she typed felt like pressing another stone onto her heart.

Xu Qingzhu: 【Then let's talk after I've finished considering it.】

Liang Shi: ...

Xu Qingzhu seemed to be acting too calm.

There was no hysteria, no questioning her for reasons. It was just like discussing business—weighing the pros and cons, then calmly telling her: I need to consider it.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. Her hair fell loose on both sides, with a strand landing on her phone screen. She raised her hand and tucked it behind her ear.

Liang Shi sent a message: 【How long will it take?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【I don't know.】

However stiff Liang Shi's questions were, Xu Qingzhu's answers were equally stiff.

Liang Shi asked again: 【So you're planning to drag this out?】

Pressing forward step by step.

Xu Qingzhu: 【No, I'm just considering.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Did you forget that my marriage to her was originally a business alliance?】

Xu Qingzhu: 【The fact that I haven't asked her to come divorce me shows that I really am seriously considering this.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【If you doubt that, we can meet right now and go to the Civil Affairs Bureau to get divorced.】

Xu Qingzhu sent several messages in a row, nearly filling up Liang Shi's phone screen.

Each sentence was harsher than the last.

Liang Shi watched the words continuously popping up on the screen, unconsciously holding her breath, nearly unable to breathe.

The pressure was too heavy.

Even through the screen, she could feel the oppressive force that Xu Qingzhu brought, as if she had cornered Liang Shi against a wall.

And those words she sent seemed to be telling Liang Shi—I was the one who married another person back then, so what right do you have to divorce me?

After staring at the screen for a long time, Liang Shi replied: 【Then take your time considering.】

In the end, she still didn't dare agree to meet with her.

And Xu Qingzhu replied: 【Okay.】

A very formulaic answer.

When this conversation ended, Liang Shi's back was drenched in cold sweat.

She couldn't explain why, but there was an irrepressible sadness in her heart.

Liang Shi walked out of the residential complex, got back in the car, numbly fastened her seatbelt, and then sat there in a daze.

It was a long while before she came back to her senses and drove away.

Not far away, a silver luxury car was parked. Xu Qingzhu sat inside, gripping her phone tightly. The veins on the back of her slender hands were bulging. She stared in the direction where that car had left until it disappeared from sight.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, and a single tear fell. After a long while, she said coldly: "Let's go."

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When Xu Qingzhu returned to the company, she happened to run into Lin Luoxi and the others coming down to eat.

"Come on." Lin Luoxi pulled her outside without another word. "Let's go eat."

Xu Qingzhu wanted to refuse, but Lin Luoxi pinched her face. "Look at you—you've gotten so thin these past few days. If you don't eat, I'm going to call Liang Shi."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

The threat worked. Xu Qingzhu smiled helplessly: "I'm really not hungry."

"How can a person not be hungry?" Lin Luoxi said. "You didn't eat breakfast this morning either. If you keep losing weight, you'll turn into a skeleton."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Can you not be so dramatic?" Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "It's not that scary."

"If you don't believe me, ask Sally." Lin Luoxi said. "Have you weighed yourself these past few days? You've lost at least five jin¹. Are you planning to enter the entertainment industry?"

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"Why would I enter the entertainment industry for no reason?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I'm already too busy with the company every day."

"Only female celebrities in the entertainment industry are competing over their figures like that."² Lin Luoxi pinched her face again, but this time she couldn't grab any flesh at all. Instead, she just pinched the skin on Xu Qingzhu's face red, making Xu Qingzhu gasp from the pain.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her: "I suspect you're taking personal revenge."

Lin Luoxi reached out to rub it for her: "What personal grudge could there be between us? Baby, I don't even have enough time to dote on you."

Her tone was intimate yet carried a hint of sarcasm, making Xu Qingzhu shiver. She immediately rubbed her arms and said: "Don't do that..."

Sally, standing to the side, looked aggrieved: "Baby, why are you calling someone else 'baby'?"

Lin Luoxi: "...You're so annoying."

Sally: "?"

"OMG." Sally looked like she'd seen a ghost. "Baby, I'm your girlfriend."

Lin Luoxi's face was cold: "So?"

Sally: "...?"

"You're not allowed to call anyone else 'baby.'" Sally said.

Xu Qingzhu, standing to the side, silently moved further away to avoid being caught up in the couple's war.

"So what if I called her that?" Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes and scoffed. "Why are you so possessive? I was calling Zhuzi, you know. Besides, even if I called a stranger that, it wouldn't be a big deal, right? You're so petty."

Sally was so angry she was speechless. Mainly because her Chinese wasn't good enough to argue back.

So she took out her phone: "I'm going to call Liang Shi and ask if she can accept it!"

Lin Luoxi: "...Are you crazy?"

Sally: "Do you have medicine?"

Lin Luoxi: "..."

Lin Luoxi pulled Xu Qingzhu forward, looking like she didn't want anyone to know she was acquainted with this idiot.

But Xu Qingzhu turned back and called out to Sally: "Don't call her."

But it was too late—Sally had already gotten through.

So Liang Shi happened to hear that sentence, and she had the illusion that she hadn't heard Xu Qingzhu's voice in a very long time.

When clearly they had only been apart for a few days.

Sally jogged to catch up with Lin Luoxi and the others, putting the phone on speaker as she went. She asked Liang Shi very righteously: "Can you accept Blanche calling someone else 'baby'?"

Liang Shi was awkward: "Uh..."

Caught off guard by this question, Liang Shi was stunned for a moment, but then asked: "Is Xu Qingzhu next to you?"

"Of course." Sally and Lin Luoxi had already taken their seats. Xu Qingzhu was holding the menu the server had handed her, pinching one corner of it. She appeared to be looking down and thinking about what to order, but she was actually listening intently to what was happening on the other end.

Sally complained: "My baby always calls other people 'baby.' She really is... too much."

Lin Luoxi held her forehead: "Just hang up already."

Sally: "No."

Lin Luoxi glared at her: "Do you want to die?"

Sally: "No."

They simply couldn't communicate.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu curled up in the corner, marked the dishes she wanted to order, then handed the menu back to the server. She sat there with her hands in her pockets, basking in the sun, with no desire to interject at all.

"Liang Shi, be the judge." Sally asked. "Can you accept it?"

Liang Shi: "...Uh."

"Don't be embarrassed." Sally said. "I can't accept it! I only want my baby to call me that."

Lin Luoxi's ears grew hot. She kicked Sally under the table. "That's enough!"

Sally grabbed her hand from across the table. "I'm just telling the truth."

Lin Luoxi pulled her hand away, saying through gritted teeth: "Have some shame."

Sally: "..."

Sally continued to press Liang Shi, clearly determined not to give up until she got an answer.

After a moment, Liang Shi answered carefully: "It's okay, I guess."

Sally was surprised: "What?"

It was only okay?!

Sally was immediately thrown into chaos. Was she the only one with such strong possessiveness?!

This didn't make sense.

"Because she wouldn't call anyone else 'baby.'" Liang Shi said over the phone. "So I don't feel anything about it."

Sally: "?"

Reasonably suspecting you're just showing off.

Sally was choked with anger. "Fine, then let's leave it at that. I'm hanging up."

1. Jin (斤) is a Chinese unit of weight. One jin equals 500 grams or approximately 1.1 pounds. Five jin would be about 2.5 kilograms or 5.5 pounds. ⇐
2. The original Chinese term "内卷" (nèi juǎn, literally "involution") refers to excessive competition where people work harder and harder just to maintain their position or get ahead, often with diminishing returns. In this context, it refers to female celebrities in China's entertainment industry competing intensely over having the thinnest figures. ⇐

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Liang Shi laughed softly on the other end of the phone, while Xu Qingzhu curled up in the corner with her eyes half-closed, seemingly unconcerned. But her tense back revealed her nervousness.

Sally didn't actually hang up. Instead, she changed the subject and asked: "What have you been busy with lately? Are you still in Haizhou? Come eat with us."

There was a pause on Liang Shi's end. "No, I'm about to head to set. You guys eat."

Sally expressed deep regret but still made plans with her to have a meal together another time.

When she was about to hang up, Sally asked Xu Qingzhu: "Blanche, do you want to say anything to Liang Shi?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "No."

A very clear and crisp sound. Even through the receiver, one could hear her cool voice.

In an instant, it suppressed all the noise in the restaurant, even though her voice was very low.

Only then did Sally hang up the phone.

After hanging up, Sally suddenly said: "Blanche, did you and Liang Shi have a fight?"

Xu Qingzhu was startled and shook her head: "No."

It was Liang Shi who unilaterally wanted a divorce.

It was her who wanted to leave.

Just the night before, they had been kissing passionately.

But after waking up, everything was gone.

It all seemed like an illusion.

And she had drunk too much wine and couldn't remember anything.

Even though she knew the reason Liang Shi was doing this was probably related to the nightmares she'd been having recently, she still couldn't accept it.

Sadness, sorrow, confusion—within a single day, she experienced every emotional up and down, going through all possible feelings.

"But I feel like something's weird between you two." Sally said.

As soon as she finished speaking, she was kicked by Lin Luoxi. "If you don't speak, no one will think you're mute."

Sally: "...I was just mentioning it."

Lin Luoxi picked up some food with her chopsticks and put it in Xu Qingzhu's bowl. "Alright, let's eat. Don't pay attention to her."

Xu Qingzhu really had no appetite. She hadn't wanted to eat anything lately.

It was probably because of Liang Shi saying she wanted a divorce.

She pushed the food around in her bowl with her chopsticks and only managed to force down a few bites.

Lin Luoxi picked up some fish with her chopsticks and gave it to her. "Try this. Their fish is very tender."

Looking at the tender white fish, Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly. For some reason, she immediately smelled a fishy odor.

"What's wrong?" Lin Luoxi asked. "Do you not want to eat it?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu answered immediately, though she looked somewhat reluctant.

Lin Luoxi frowned: "Baby, you really can't go on like this. You'll ruin your health."

Worried about making her concerned, Xu Qingzhu picked up a piece with her chopsticks and put it in her mouth. "I know... urgh..."

Before she could finish speaking, she felt nauseous—a wave of nausea rising from the depths of her stomach.

She immediately covered her mouth and ran outside.

Fortunately, it was only dry heaving.

But then came an even stronger wave of nausea. The server nearby was also startled and immediately took her to the restroom.

In the restroom, she hunched over the sink and dry heaved for a while, then actually threw up. Her face was deathly pale.

She had thrown up almost everything she had just eaten, until she was vomiting stomach acid.

Xu Qingzhu turned on the faucet to wash away the mess, then cupped some water to rinse her mouth.

This sudden incident had scared Lin Luoxi quite badly. She stood beside her, patting her back.

After quite a while, Xu Qingzhu finally recovered. Lin Luoxi handed her a bottle of water.

Xu Qingzhu rinsed her mouth before drinking. But shortly after drinking the water, she felt like dry heaving again.

It took a lot of effort to suppress it.

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the wall, her whole being looking weak.

"You and Liang Shi..." Lin Luoxi paused before asking. "Is it serious?"

Xu Qingzhu was startled: "What?"

"Are you two having a cold war?" Lin Luoxi said, then immediately dismissed the idea herself.

"You love her so much, how could that be? Then you..."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. Her half-closed eyes' lashes trembled slightly as she shook her head: "I don't know."

She had been like this with food lately.

Lin Luoxi thought for a moment, then asked in a low voice: "Are you... pregnant?"

Xu Qingzhu immediately denied it: "That's not possi—"

The words got stuck halfway through, and all the color drained from her face.